

See also: The Poor Laws 88–91 ■ INTERPOL 220–221 ■ Euthanasia 296–297 ■ The International Convention Against Doping in Sport 304

a comprehensive drug strategy, drawn up by Goulão, that focused on support for users rather than continuing criminalization. Law 30, setting out the legal framework for the treatment of drug users and provision for their welfare, was passed in the year 2000 and came into force in July 2001.

The law decriminalized drug use but did not legalize it. Drug use remains an administrative violation in Portugal, and distributing and selling drugs is still a serious crime. But possession and use is seen as a public health problem, not a criminal offense. Anyone caught with less than 10 days' supply of drugs is brought before a local commission and steered toward psychiatrists, health workers, and counselors—not the police.

Between 1999 and 2003, as more drug treatment centers opened in Portugal, drug-related deaths more than halved, rates of HIV/AIDS infection from contaminated needles fell dramatically, and far fewer teenagers were using hard drugs. The trend has largely continued. Despite a small peak in drug-induced deaths in 2015,



Drug-induced deaths per million in population:

■ More than 40 ■ 10–40 ■ Fewer than 10
■ Data unavailable

List of countries:

- | | |
|--------------------|---------------|
| 1. Portugal | 17. Hungary |
| 2. Spain | 18. Slovakia |
| 3. Ireland | 19. Poland |
| 4. United Kingdom | 20. Sweden |
| 5. France | 21. Greece |
| 6. Belgium | 22. Bulgaria |
| 7. Luxembourg | 23. Romania |
| 8. Netherlands | 24. Lithuania |
| 9. Italy | 25. Latvia |
| 10. Germany | 26. Estonia |
| 11. Denmark | 27. Finland |
| 12. Norway | 28. Turkey |
| 13. Croatia | |
| 14. Slovenia | |
| 15. Austria | |
| 16. Czech Republic | |

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Drug-induced deaths—overdoses and poisonings directly attributed to taking illegal drugs—averaged 22.6 per million people in Europe and Turkey in 2017. Portugal had only four such deaths per million of its population. Of all 8,238 deaths recorded, 34 percent occurred in the UK.

Portugal's average has remained lower than that of any other European country.

An example to follow

The Netherlands, Germany, Italy, the Czech Republic, and Spain had decriminalized some drug use by statute or in practice by the year 2000, and Estonia, Croatia, Poland, and Switzerland have since followed suit. However, Portugal was the first European country to decriminalize all drug use, and it has seen a more dramatic fall in drug-related deaths than any of these countries.

Portuguese drug users wait beside a treatment van in Lisbon to receive their daily doses of methadone. Two of these vans operate each day in the city, serving around 1,200 patients a year.

Portugal's winning strategy seems to have been its decision to back decriminalization of all drug use with generous funding for initiatives such as drop-in centers, syringe-exchange schemes, and opioid substitution programs. Lifting criminal sanctions for drug use has freed up resources to treat users and pursue dealers and traffickers.

Globally, more than 20 nations now have some kind of drug-use decriminalization laws, as have the Virgin Islands, 18 US states, and three Australian states. In 2019, representatives of 31 UN agencies all endorsed decriminalization of possession and use of drugs. While criminalizing drug use is still the status quo in most countries, more now acknowledge that, like Portugal, they must find a better way. ■